

NEW PLAY LICENSING • FULL-LENGTH • 2-ACT • ENSEMBLE OF 10

Play It Straight

A high school teacher, a conservative community, a new assistant principal, and a classroom of drama students caught in the crossfire in a state where *chaos and control* have stopped pretending to coexist.

CAST

10+ ensemble

RUNTIME

~110 minutes

SET

Single unit, flexible

STATUS

Available to license

[REQUEST LICENSING INFORMATION →](#)

[READ MORE](#)

01 — THE PLAY

A comedy about the *impossible* job of teaching teenagers to tell the truth.

Ross has been teaching high school drama for longer than most of his students have been alive, and he'd tell you he's pretty good at it — as long as nobody gets in his way.

Then a throwaway sarcastic line in rehearsal gets reported to a deputy sheriff. A new assistant principal discovers her district has a mandatory outing policy. A student's Bible painting of a smiling Jesus collides with online rage-radio. And the Spring production of *Romeo and Juliet* starts falling apart in ways Shakespeare never imagined.

Written by three theater makers with decades of classroom experience between them, *Play It Straight* looks at what happens when the adults who are supposed to be in charge are the ones most out of their depth — and the kids, for once, are the ones holding the line.

It's a play about control. About chaos. About whether the two can share a room without killing each other. And about what a teacher owes to a student

■ **PLAY IT STRAIGHT** when the law says one thing and the kid's life says another.

IDENTITY

STUDENT AGENCY

LGBTQ+ THEMES

COMEDY + DRAMA

ENSEMBLE

10+

4 adults / 6 students

RUNTIME

110

minutes, two acts

GENRE

Comedy

with serious teeth

ROYALTY

\$100

per performance

02 — FROM THE SCRIPT

Lights up to reveal ROSS, a high school Drama teacher, standing in front of what appear to be 3 dead students. JENNY lies in state, on a funeral bier; IVAN is sprawled downstage of her, his face gory with blood which has gushed from his mouth; HOPE lies nearby, a cup in her hand, a dagger and an open binder just downstage of her head.

ROSS

Most important thing about teaching? Control the classroom. If you can't do that, nothing else you do is gonna matter.

(gestures at the corpses)

■ **PLAY IT STRAIGHT** This right here? First time I've felt in control since last Tuesday. It won't last, but can we just take a moment to enjoy it together?

(deep, meditative breath)

This is nice.

03 — WRITERS

Three writers. *One* play.

Richard Winters

PLAYWRIGHT

Richard Winters, drawing on his decades of experience as a Drama and English teacher in California public high schools, hosts a series of off-campus improv/writing workshops with a small group of his Drama students. The plan: write a comedy based on a funny story he used to tell at parties — about the time a careless comment to a disruptive student sparked an investigation into his conduct and classroom management style, and led to an official reprimand, and one of his worst-ever days at work.

Kerri Yund

PLAYWRIGHT

Kerri Yund, a former student of Richard's, stays with the project, and the writing continues. The forcible outing of Hope to her father in adherence to district policy is Kerri's suggestion, based on similar policies which exist in many states where right wing Christian nationalists have infiltrated local school boards. The tone of the play turns darker. It's no longer a comedy. Although Kerri's family does not closely resemble Hope's family, Hope's storyline is heavily

influenced and informed by Kerri's lived experience as a closeted gay high school student, taking
■ **PLAY IT STRAIGHT** refuge in the place where she feels safest — in Richard Winters' Drama class. After high school,

Kerri went on to edit the Daily Bruin at UCLA, and is now a Second Grade teacher in Sacramento. She credits Richard as a major influence in her decision to become an educator.

Gary Wright

PLAYWRIGHT

Gary Wright, long-time friend and theatre colleague of Richard's, and a seasoned writer with play commissions from Foothill Theatre Company, Sacramento Theatre Company, Arizona Theatre Matters, and the Palo Alto Childrens' Theatre, comes aboard to lead the next phase of the work. From here on, the mission is character development, and experimenting with different variations of the second act. We wrote a lot of endings we didn't like. The second half got very complicated and very dark for a while there. Finally, simplifying and focusing Act Two on everyone finding their power and pushing back against oppression was Gary's idea — inspired by yet another funny story from Richard's long and eventful teaching career.

*"Who's in **control** here?
You tell me."*

— ROSS, END OF ACT ONE

REQUEST LICENSING INFORMATION →

Play It *Straight*

A NEW PLAY • 2026

CONTACT

Richard Winters

Kerri Yund

Gary Wright

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[Script Excerpt](#)

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ABOUT THE PLAY

About *the Play*

Play It Straight is a contemporary drama set in a public high school where a classroom comment ignites a broader political and cultural conflict.

01 — SYNOPSIS

What *happens*.

When drama teacher Ross sarcastically tells a disruptive student to "sit on my lap," the moment is reported by a parent and escalates into a formal administrative inquiry.

As the school attempts to protect itself legally, students — particularly LGBTQ students — find their safety and autonomy threatened. The arts classroom, once a place of creativity and refuge, becomes a battleground over what can be said, who can exist openly, and who controls the narrative.

■ **PLAY IT STRAIGHT** The play examines the consequences of politicizing education and the human cost of institutional self-protection.

It asks what it means to stand up for yourself and others when doing so carries real consequences — and what a teacher owes to a student when the law says one thing and the kid's life says another.

IDENTITY

STUDENT AGENCY

LGBTQ+ THEMES

CENSORSHIP

COMEDY + DRAMA

PARENTAL AUTHORITY

02 — FOR STUDENTS

What it's *really* about.

Play It Straight takes place in a high school drama class where students are encouraged to be creative and honest. When a joke during rehearsal is misunderstood and reported, the situation quickly grows into something much bigger than anyone expected.

Students find themselves caught between parents, administrators, and school policy. For some — especially LGBTQ students — the conflict becomes deeply personal. The play asks what it means to stand up for yourself and others when doing so carries real consequences.

Themes

- Student agency and autonomy
- LGBTQ+ visibility and belonging
- Artistic expression and censorship
- Parental authority and institutional pressure

03 - PRODUCTION DETAILS

Built for *your* program.

By the Numbers

- Authors: Richard Winters, Kerri Yund, Gary Wright
- Running time: Approximately two hours, plus intermission
- Cast: 10+ actors total (4 adults, 6+ students)
- Doubling: No specified doubling
- Staging: Flexible – black box-friendly
- Royalty: \$100 per performance

Who Can Produce It

Available for production by community colleges, colleges, universities, and community theaters.

Several roles are explicitly open-gender, giving directors room to cast to the company in front of them. A few roles require specific representation; the character descriptions make that clear.

REQUEST A PERUSAL SCRIPT →

ENSEMBLE

10

4 adults / 6 students

RUNTIME

110

minutes, two acts

STAGING

One

flexible school unit

ROYALTY

\$100

per performance

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT

you *produce.*

This play contains strong language, homophobic slurs, discussion of conversion therapy, political extremism themes, accusations of misconduct, and mature discussions of sexuality and identity.

Organizations are encouraged to engage thoughtfully with the play's themes. Production approval is handled directly and collaboratively to support organizations in presenting the work responsibly and successfully.

Play It *Straight*

A NEW PLAY • 2026

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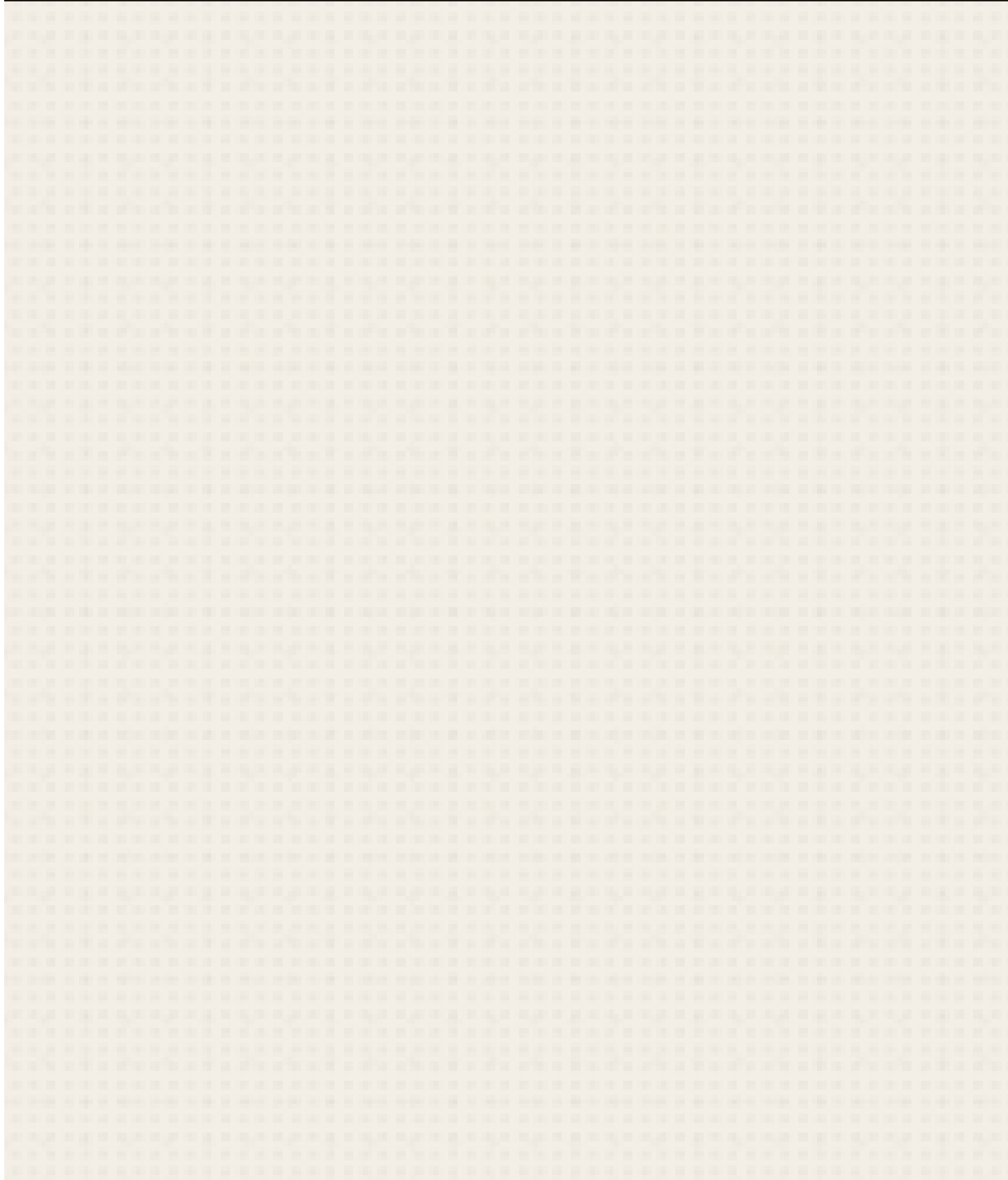
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■ **PLAY IT STRAIGHT**

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PRODUCTION GALLERY

Production *Gallery*

Photos from the table reads, openings, and staged productions.

01 — SACRAMENTO CITY COLLEGE-2024

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ROSS & GABE

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



BEACHER & HEWITT

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



STERN

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



HEWITT • GABE • MORGAN



CJ

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ROSS AND STUDENTS

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



HOPE AND HEWITT

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



HOPE AND ROSS

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



JENNY AND ROSS

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



TIK TOK CHALLENGE

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT

R25 Theater Company with the support of California Stage presents



PLAY IT STRAIGHT

A new play by Richard Winters, Gary Wright, and Kerri Yund

Directed by Richard Winters

R25 FLYER



GABE

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



STC – FIRST PUBLIC READING

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



STC – FIRST READING, CURTAIN CALL

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



play

by richard winters,
gary wright & kerri yund

it

straight

A NEW WORK FROM LOCAL PLAYWRIGHTS

reading series

SACRAMENTO PREMIERE

BLACK BOX THEATRE

PAY WHAT YOU CAN

OCT 15-19 2024



CRC POSTER

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



STAGE MANAGER

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ANTHONY D'JUAN - DIRECTOR

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ENSEMBLE

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



JENNY AND THESPIS

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ROSS AND CJ



MUSKEGON PRIDE DONATION

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ENSEMBLE CAST — COSUMNES RIVER COLLEGE

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



ENSEMBLE — R25 THEATER COMPANY

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



SIERRA THEATER COMPANY

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



MUSKEGON TABLE READ

[SEE THE PRODUCTIONS →](#)

Play It *Straight*

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PRODUCTION HISTORY

Past *Productions*

A reverse-chronological archive of productions of *Play It Straight* — venues, creative teams, and photos.

APRIL 2025

COLLEGE PRODUCTION

CAST OF 10

Sacramento City College

Sacramento, CA

A college production that leaned into the script's comedic beats while preserving the emotional weight of the final act. The student ensemble brought strong chemistry and the intimate staging drew audiences into the conflict.

"The students owned the stage from the first line. You could hear the audience holding their breath during the inquiry scene."

DIRECTOR

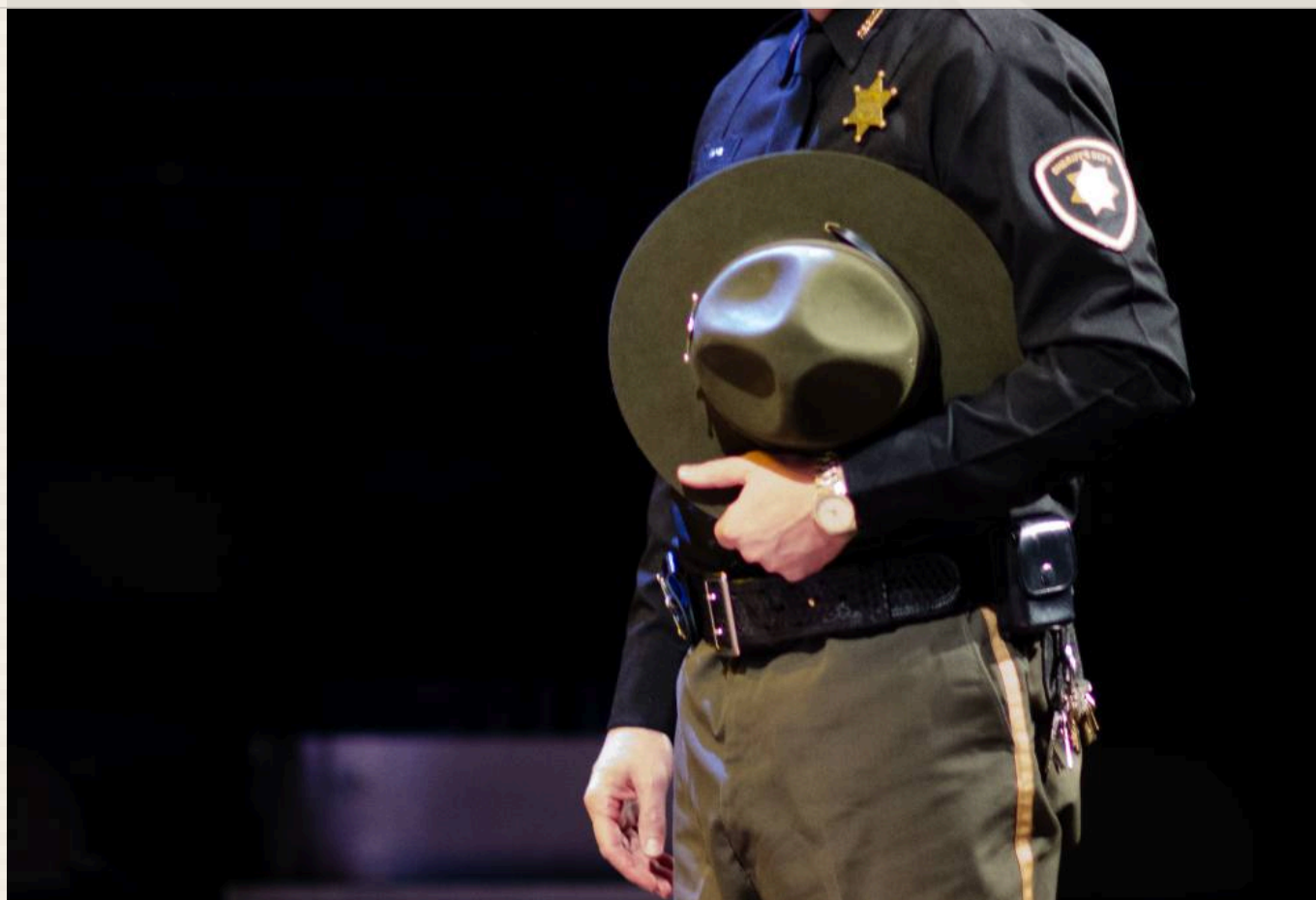
■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



APRIL 2025

OPENING NIGHT

STAGED READING

Opening Run

Staged performances • April 2025

A pair of performances that gave the script its first full audience test. Rapid tonal shifts from comedy to reckoning landed as intended, and the ensemble structure proved flexible enough to absorb last-minute casting changes.

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT *"It started exactly the kind of conversation our community needed."*

AUDIENCE MEMBER



■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT





TABLE READ

DEVELOPMENTAL

CAST OF 10

Muskegon Table Read

Muskegon, MI

A developmental table read that let the writers hear the script in full before rehearsal. Notes from this read shaped the pacing of Act Two and sharpened the deputy-principal confrontation that closes Act One.

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT *"Proof of the jokes are the Trojan horse. The play ends up somewhere else entirely."*

■ ATTENDING PLAYWRIGHT



■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT



*Stage your **own** production.*

— LICENSING AVAILABLE

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REACTIONS & TESTIMONIALS

What people *are saying*

01 — DIRECTORS & AUDIENCES

"Play It Straight is a lucid dramatic work that transcends our current socio-political reality due to its carefully crafted characters who represent various facets of the American experience in their commitment to change their lives through love, human understanding, dialogue and a desire to improve society. A riveting play which speaks to the tenor of our changing times. I was emotionally moved by the play's ability to inspire hope for future generations."

ROBERTO D. POMO, PH.D. — PROFESSOR EMERITUS, SACRAMENTO STATE UNIVERSITY

"We LOVE this play. Hearing it out loud and having actual students read the student parts brought it to life. This is a really good, tight script... The excitement from the students

...was electric... I cannot think of a better piece of theatre to be working on right now."

ADAM BELL — ACTORS' WORKSHOP DIRECTOR, MUSKEGON, MI

"It brought me to tears. It knocked my socks off. It completely engaged me emotionally and intellectually. Simply put it was an 11 out of 10. I see a lot of theater locally and further afield and, to me, this work has more potential than anything new I have seen in many years."

MICHAEL BURNSTEIN — R25 THEATRE GROUP AUDIENCE, SACRAMENTO, CA

"I brought a bunch of my students to see it, and they were crazy about it! The relationship between the conservative father and his daughter is nuanced and moving — and, of course, the portrayal of the untenable position our teachers are in is heartbreaking!"

MELANIE SMITH — TEACHER, R25 THEATRE GROUP AUDIENCE, SACRAMENTO, CA

"Sorry Angels in America, this is the best play I've ever seen, and it's not even finished yet."

SANDRA BALTHAZAR — SIERRA STAGES STAGED READING AUDIENCE, NEVADA CITY, CA

"I'm not a theater major or critic, but I've seen lots of plays, classic and modern, and this, in my opinion, is masterful writing. It's among the best new works I've seen."

JIM HEFTER — STAGED READING AUDIENCE, NEVADA CITY, CA

"I wanted to say what a pleasure it was to see Play It Straight this past weekend. I was laughing, I was crying, and the show flew by like spending time with a good friend. I enjoyed how there was no true 'bad guy' in the show. It was a dad trying to do his best raising his two kids on his own. A principal trying to keep the balance between policy, parents, students, and the law. A teacher creating a space where the kids are allowed to be themselves and through that things go haywire. It's kids becoming adults and figuring out how they want to interact with the world. Play It Straight was a truly moving piece of work and I am beyond glad I was able to see this current rendition. Have a great closing weekend! Break legs"

LAUREN — R25 THEATER COMPANY, 2025 PRODUCTION

"I saw Play It Straight at the Stage at the Corner. I've been thinking about it, even now, a week after I saw it. It's a tough show, but I couldn't stop watching and found myself emotionally more and more involved. It was a fabulous play. I urge you to see it."

■ **PLAY IT STRAIGHT**

02 — PRESS & RECOGNITION

VIDEO TESTIMONIALS

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT

VIDEO TESTIMONIAL PLACEHOLDER

Optional video testimonials from faculty or students.

PRESS & RECOGNITION

— TBD award or recognition

— TBD festival selection

SEE THE PRODUCTIONS →

Play It *Straight*

A NEW PLAY • 2026

CONTACT

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SCRIPT EXCERPT

From the *Script*

Selected scenes from *Play It Straight*. For a full perusal script, contact the playwrights.

ACT ONE — OPENING

Lights up to reveal ROSS, a high school Drama teacher, standing in front of what appear to be 3 dead students. JENNY lies in state, on a funeral bier; IVAN is sprawled downstage of her, his face gory with blood which has gushed from his mouth; HOPE lies nearby, a cup in her hand, a dagger and an open binder just downstage of her head.

ROSS

Most important thing about teaching? Control the classroom. If you can't do that, nothing else you do is gonna matter.

(gestures at the corpses)

This, right here? First time I've felt in control since last Tuesday. It won't last, but can we just take a moment to enjoy it together?

(deep, meditative breath)

ACT ONE — THE COMPLAINT

Administrative office, the next morning. HEWITT, the new Assistant Principal — fresh off her first week of her first admin job — is alone. STERN, a uniformed Deputy Sheriff, has come in person, unannounced, demanding to speak with the Principal.

STERN

Yesterday afternoon, David Isaac Ross, the man who runs your theatre program, asked my son to sit on his lap.

(beat)

My son is a sophomore — he's 15 years old — I want him removed from that class, effective immediately. And, I am recommending that you remove Mr. Ross from the classroom as well, and initiate an independent investigation into his misconduct. Did you get all that?

HEWITT

Mr. Stern, it sounds like you're making a lot of assumptions based on circumstantial—

STERN

Based on experience, ma'am. I've been in law enforcement over twenty years — I've seen some things. You learn to trust your gut.

HEWITT

Well, I don't have the benefit of your experience, so I need you to be explicit. What, exactly, do you imagine your gut is telling you about Mr.

STERN

Put it this way: If I asked you to sit on my lap right now — what would your gut be telling you about me?

| *Pause.*

HEWITT

I think you're wrong about what's going on here, but I will see to it that your son is removed from that class.

ACT TWO — THE FLASHBACK

| *A prep period, months earlier. Between a lockdown drill and the bell, HOPE tells ROSS about a painting on a kids' Bible her parents gave her when she was four — a smiling Jesus holding a lamb, surrounded by kids.*

HOPE

It was cute! Of course it was white Jesus, so I just thought, that's my Dad. Probably because he's so good with little kids. He used to get me laughing so hard I couldn't breathe — and then I got older and watched him do the same thing with CJ — he's amazing at it. With toddlers.

| *(beat)*

Teenagers, not so much. You start having a mind of your own, and he's way out of his comfort zone. If Mom hadn't left — it'd be easier.

ROSS

Where'd she go?

HOPE

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT

Cincinnati, her sister lives there. Then she kept going. Don't know, don't care. She just left.

Silence.

HOPE

And then it seemed like Dad was mad all the time. All I know is, he doesn't make us laugh very much anymore. He saves the humor for his "online community."

(a difficult admission)

I'll come out to him someday, but not while I'm living under his roof. Nooo thanks! I'd rather just... let him think I'm who he thinks I am.

REQUEST FULL PERUSAL

These excerpts represent a fraction of the script. Contact the playwrights to request a full perusal copy for licensing consideration.

Request Full Script

Interested in producing? We'll provide a full perusal script, an author's note on staging choices, and a conversation with the writers if that's useful to your program.

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Play It *Straight*

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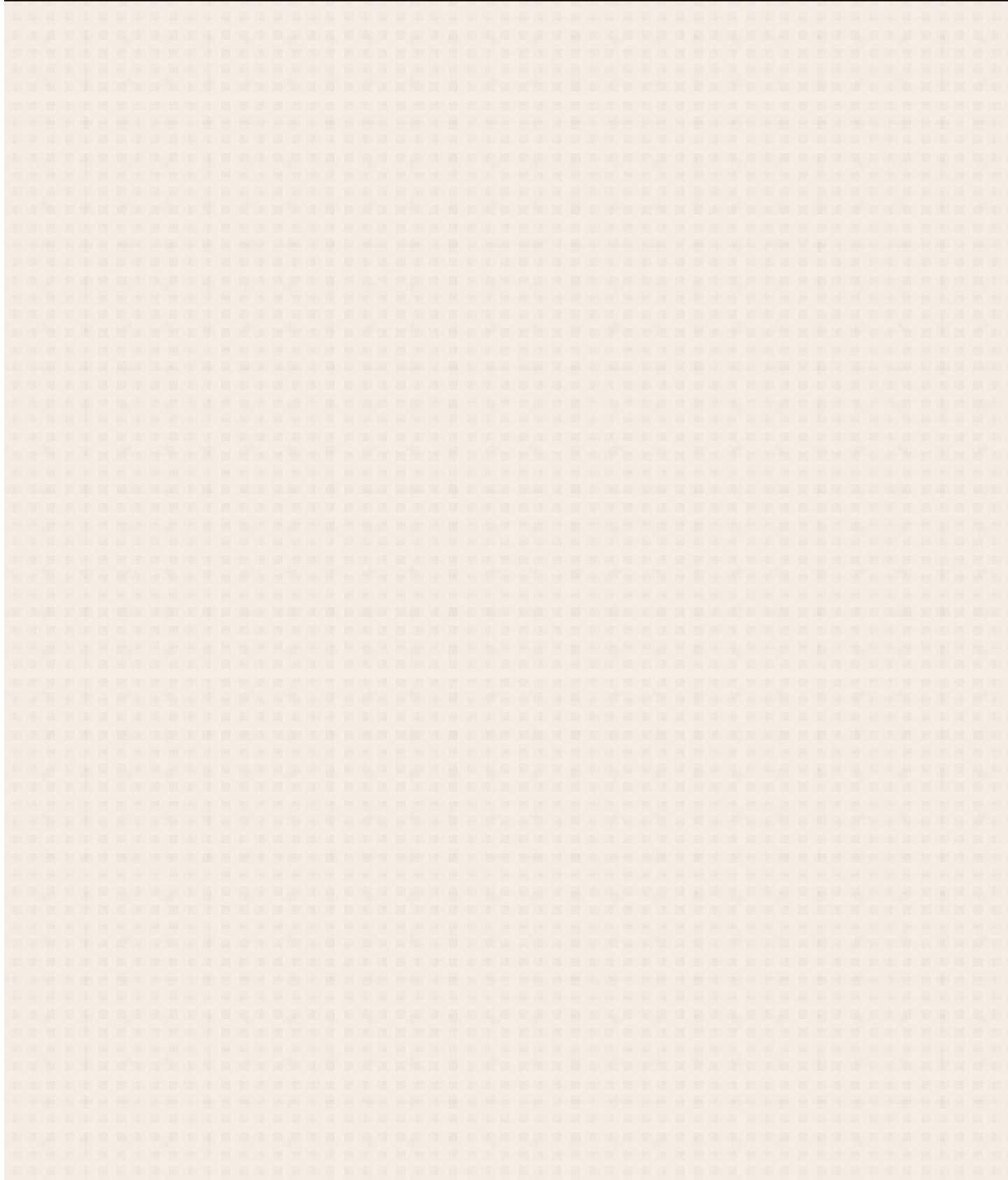
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L I C E N S I N G & B O O K I N G

Produce *this play*

Play It Straight is available for production by community colleges, colleges, universities, and community theaters.

01 — R O Y A L T Y

\$100

per performance • flat rate • no minimum

02 — H O W I T W O R K S

Booking *process.*

1. Submit your inquiry through the contact form
2. Include your organization name and anticipated performance dates
3. Receive direct follow-up on licensing approval and performance rights

FAQ.

- Who can produce this play? Community colleges, colleges, universities, and community theaters.
- Is this black box friendly? Yes. Staging is flexible with manageable technical requirements.
- How do we request rights? Contact the playwright directly using the site contact form.
- Is there a minimum run? No minimum performance requirement is specified.

03 - A NOTE

Producing *responsibly.*

Organizations are encouraged to engage thoughtfully with the play's themes, which include free expression, identity, and the role of the arts in public education.

Production approval is handled directly and collaboratively to support organizations in presenting the work responsibly and successfully.

All licensing inquiries: richardwinters11@gmail.com

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GET IN TOUCH

Request *Licensing Info*

Whether you're an educator, student director, administrator, or community theater rep — we'd love to hear from you.

01 — INQUIRIES

Use the form to inquire about licensing, performance rights, or additional materials. Please include your organization name and anticipated performance dates if available.

All inquiries are handled directly by the playwrights.

DIRECT CONTACT

richardwinters11@gmail.com

kerriyund@gmail.com

garyunchained@yahoo.com

Royalty: **\$100 per performance**

NAME

■ PLAY IT STRAIGHT

INSTITUTION

EMAIL

INTENDED PRODUCTION DATES (OPTIONAL)

MESSAGE

SEND LICENSING INQUIRY →

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